

Word family: **cushion / cushions / cushioned / cushioning / cushiony**

Base word: cushion

Plural: cushions

Verb forms: cushions, cushioned, cushioning

Major related forms:

* cushioned

* cushioning

* cushiony — informal, relatively low-frequency

* uncushioned — genuine but lower-frequency

Major compounds/extensions:

* seat cushion

* back cushion

* floor cushion

* throw cushion

* cushion cover

* air cushion

* cushioning material

* financial cushion

* cash cushion

* liquidity cushion

* capital cushion

* safety cushion

* time cushion

* cushion against

* cushion the blow

* cushion a fall

* cushion someone from something

* cushion of points/goals

* billiard/snooker cushion

* cushion gas

* cushion plant

* cushion capital

* cushion cut

* pincushion

* whoopee cushion

* broadcast cushion

Your passage:

> “If you leave now without a financial **cushion**, one bad month may force you to borrow money...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **cushion** is figurative. It means:

> **a reserve of money that protects Kam Chai from financial difficulty if income falls or unexpected costs arise.**

繁體中文：

* **財務緩衝**

* **財務安全墊**

* **備用資金**

* **應急儲備**

So:

> **financial cushion**

= **「財務安全墊 / 應急資金」**

The physical metaphor is very clear:

> a physical cushion absorbs an impact

> → savings absorb a financial shock.

A strong translation is:

> 「如果你現在離職，卻沒有足夠的**財務安全墊**，只要生意有一個月不順，就可能迫使你借錢。」

A. CUSHION = SOFT PAD

1. **cushion** = soft padded object used for comfort or support (**軟墊** ; **靠墊**)

This is the central literal noun sense.

> “She put a cushion behind her back.”

「她在背後放了一個**靠墊**。」

A cushion is typically:

* fabric/leather/plastic exterior;

- * filled with foam, feathers, air, etc.;
- * used for sitting, leaning, kneeling, or support.

B. SEAT CUSHION

2. **seat cushion = 坐墊**

> “The chair needs a new seat cushion.”

「這張椅子需要換一個**坐墊**。」

C. BACK CUSHION

3. **back cushion = 靠背墊**

Supports the back.

D. SOFA CUSHIONS

4. **sofa/couch cushion = 梳化墊 / 沙發坐墊或靠墊**

Can refer to:

- * seat cushion;
- * back cushion;
- * loose decorative cushion.

E. THROW / SCATTER CUSHION

5. **throw cushion / scatter cushion = 裝飾靠墊**

Small decorative cushion placed on:

- * sofa;
- * bed;
- * chair.

Throw pillow is more common in AmE.

F. FLOOR CUSHION

6. **floor cushion = 地墊 / 大型坐墊**

Designed for sitting directly on the floor.

G. CUSHION COVER

7. **cushion cover = 靠墊套**

Removable outer fabric covering.

H. CUSHION FILLING

8. **cushion filling = 靠墊填充物**

Could include:

- * foam;
- * feathers/down;
- * polyester fibre;
- * air.

I. CUSHION = SOFT PROTECTIVE PAD

9. **cushion = soft layer/pad protecting against pressure, rubbing or impact (緩衝墊) **

This extends the domestic-object meaning.

> “The packaging contains a foam cushion.”

「包裝內有一層泡棉**緩衝墊**。」

Collins explicitly records **cushion** as a soft pad/barrier used to protect something. ([柯林斯詞典]
[1])

J. PACKAGING CUSHION

10. **packaging cushion = 包裝緩衝物**

Protects fragile goods from:

- * shock;
- * vibration;
- * compression.

Examples:

- * foam;
- * air pillows;
- * molded inserts.

K. CUSHIONING MATERIAL

11. **cushioning material = 緩衝材料**

A material designed to:

> absorb impact / distribute pressure / reduce vibration.

L. CUSHIONING — NOUN

12. **cushioning = material or process that softens impact (緩衝 ; 緩衝層) **

> “The shoes provide excellent cushioning.”

「這雙鞋提供很好的**緩震效果**。」

Common in:

- * footwear;
- * sports equipment;
- * packaging;
- * furniture.

M. VERB: CUSHION AN IMPACT

13. **cushion = reduce the force of an impact (緩衝) **

> “The padding cushioned the impact.”

「墊料**減輕了撞擊力**。」

This is the basic verb sense.

N. CUSHION A FALL

14. **cushion a fall = 減輕跌落時的撞擊**

> “The soft ground cushioned his fall.”

「柔軟的地面**減輕了他跌倒時的衝擊**。」

Very common.

O. CUSHION A LANDING

15. **cushion a landing = 緩和着地衝擊**

> “The mat cushioned her landing.”

「墊子**緩衝了她着地時的衝擊**。」

P. CUSHION SOMEONE'S HEAD / BODY

16. **cushion X = place/support it against something soft**

> “She cushioned the baby's head with her hand.”

「她用手**托住並緩衝嬰兒的頭部**。」

Q. CUSHION FROM / AGAINST

17. **cushion someone/something from X = reduce X's harmful effect (保護.....免受 / 減輕.....影響) **

> “The suspension cushions passengers from road vibration.”

「懸掛系統可**減輕道路震動對乘客的影響**。」

Collins records this construction directly. ([柯林斯詞典][2])

18. **cushion against X**

> “The insulation provides a cushion against vibration.”

「隔離層可以**緩衝震動**。」

As noun or verb, **against** emphasizes protection from an adverse force.

R. AIR CUSHION

19. **air cushion = layer/pocket of air providing support or shock absorption (氣墊) **

Cambridge records **cushion of air** for a supporting layer of air, such as beneath a hovercraft.
([劍橋詞典][3])

Examples:

- * hovercraft;
- * machinery;
- * packaging;
- * landing systems.

S. AIR-CUSHION VEHICLE

20. **air-cushion vehicle = 氣墊交通工具**

A vehicle supported wholly or partly by a pressurized layer of air.

A hovercraft is the familiar example.

T. SHOE / SPORTS CUSHIONING

21. **shoe cushioning = 鞋底緩震**

Designed to reduce:

- * impact loading;
- * discomfort;
- * pressure.

Common phrases:

- * heel cushioning
- * forefoot cushioning
- * cushioned sole
- * cushioned running shoe.

U. CUSHIONED SOLE / INSOLE

22. **cushioned sole / cushioned insole = 緩震鞋底 / 鞋墊**

> “The shoes have cushioned insoles.”

「鞋內有**緩震鞋墊**。」

V. CUSHIONED SEAT

23. **cushioned seat = 有軟墊的座位**

Here **cushioned** simply means:

> fitted/padded with cushions.

W. CUSHIONED FURNITURE

24. **cushioned chair/bench = 有軟墊的椅 / 長椅**

X. FIGURATIVE CUSHION = PROTECTION FROM HARDSHIP

Now the branch directly underlying your passage.

25. **cushion = something that reduces the harmful effect of hardship/shock (緩衝 ; 安全墊)

**

> “Savings provide a cushion against unemployment.”

「積蓄可以成為失業時的**財務安全墊**。」

Collins explicitly gives the example of an inheritance serving as a cushion against unemployment.
([柯林斯詞典][1])

Y. FINANCIAL CUSHION

26. **financial cushion = financial reserve that absorbs unexpected loss/cost (財務安全墊) **

Your exact passage branch.

Possible components:

- * cash savings;
- * emergency fund;
- * liquid assets;
- * unused borrowing capacity,

depending on context.

Z. CASH CUSHION

27. **cash cushion = 額外現金儲備**

> “Keep a cash cushion for unexpected bills.”

「保留一些**備用現金**應付突發開支。」

AA. EMERGENCY-FUND CUSHION

28. **emergency cushion = 應急緩衝資金**

Less fixed than:

> emergency fund

but natural.

AB. LIQUIDITY CUSHION

29. **liquidity cushion = 流動性緩衝**

Finance/banking/corporate treasury:

> readily available liquid resources that help an entity meet cash needs under stress.

This is broader/more technical than an individual's savings cushion.

AC. CAPITAL CUSHION

30. **capital cushion = 資本緩衝**

A layer of capital available to absorb losses.

Used especially in:

- * banking;
- * corporate finance;
- * prudential discussion.

Often conceptually close to:

> capital buffer.

AD. EARNINGS / PROFIT CUSHION

31. **earnings cushion / profit cushion = 額外盈利緩衝**

Extra earnings/margin that can absorb:

- * cost increases;

- * revenue shortfalls;
- * unexpected losses.

More business-journalistic than technical.

AE. SAFETY CUSHION

32. **safety cushion = 額外安全餘量**

General figurative phrase.

> “Build in a safety cushion.”

「預留一些**安全餘量**。」

AF. CUSHION OF TIME

33. **time cushion = 額外預留時間**

> “Leave a twenty-minute cushion before the meeting.”

「開會前預留二十分鐘的**時間緩衝**。」

This means:

> extra time in case something goes wrong.

AG. SCHEDULE CUSHION

34. **schedule cushion = 進度緩衝時間**

Similar to:

- * buffer;
- * slack;
- * contingency.

AH. COST / BUDGET CUSHION

35. **budget cushion = 預算緩衝 / 預備金**

Extra budget intentionally retained for:

- * overruns;
- * uncertainty;
- * unexpected costs.

AI. MARGIN / LEAD AS A CUSHION

36. **cushion = comfortable extra margin that protects against later loss (領先優勢 ; 餘量)**

> “They went into half-time with a ten-point cushion.”

「他們半場時有**十分的領先優勢**。」

Very common in:

- * sport;
- * elections;
- * business performance;
- * competition.

AJ. POINT CUSHION

37. **a five-point cushion = 五分領先優勢**

> “The team built a five-point cushion.”

「球隊建立了**五分優勢**。」

AK. GOAL CUSHION

38. **a two-goal cushion = 兩球領先優勢**

Common sports commentary.

AL. LEAD CUSHION

39. **a comfortable cushion / healthy cushion = 相當安全的領先 / 餘量**

> “The company has a healthy cash cushion.”

or:

> “The runner built a comfortable cushion.”

Same protective-margin metaphor.

AM. GIVE YOURSELF A CUSHION

40. **give yourself a cushion = deliberately create extra margin (給自己留餘地) **

> “Leave early to give yourself a cushion.”

「早點出發，給自己**留點餘裕**。」

Can concern:

- * time;
- * money;
- * performance targets;
- * deadlines.

AN. BUILD IN A CUSHION

41. **build a cushion into something = 預留緩衝**

> “Build a 10% cushion into the budget.”

「預算中預留 10% 的**緩衝額**。」

AO. VERB: CUSHION THE BLOW

42. **cushion the blow = make bad news/loss/change less painful (減輕打擊) **

One of the most important figurative idioms.

> “The savings cushioned the blow of losing his job.”

「積蓄**減輕了失業帶來的打擊**。」

AP. SOFTEN THE BLOW VS CUSHION THE BLOW

soften the blow

make an unpleasant event/news feel less severe.

cushion the blow

same basic metaphor, often emphasizing practical/financial protection.

Large overlap.

AQ. CUSHION LOSSES

43. **cushion losses = 減輕損失**

> “Higher sales helped cushion the losses.”

「較高銷售額幫助**減輕損失**。」

AR. CUSHION THE EFFECT / IMPACT

44. **cushion the impact/effect = 緩和影響**

> “The reserve fund cushioned the impact of rising costs.”

「儲備基金**緩和了成本上升的影響**。」

AS. CUSHION SOMEONE FROM ECONOMIC SHOCK

45. **cushion X from/against shocks = 保護 X 免受衝擊**

Examples:

- * households from inflation;
- * businesses from demand shocks;
- * workers from unemployment.

AT. SOCIAL-POLICY CUSHION

46. **cushion against hardship = 困境緩衝 / 社會安全墊**

Benefits, savings, insurance, family support etc. can be described as:

> a cushion against hardship.

AU. ECONOMIC CUSHION

47. **economic cushion = 經濟緩衝**

Resources/conditions reducing the consequences of a downturn.

AV. CUSHION = BARRIER / SEPARATING LAYER

48. **cushion = protective layer between two things (緩衝層) **

> “A layer of foam forms a cushion between the parts.”

「泡棉在兩個部件之間形成**緩衝層**。」

This is physical but extends naturally to abstract contexts.

AW. ANATOMY / ZOOLOGY

49. **cushion = pad-like body structure (墊狀組織) **

Dictionaries record **cushion** in anatomy/zoology for a part or structure resembling a soft pad.
([柯林斯詞典][1])

Examples can include:

- * fatty pads;
- * soft tissue;
- * pressure-distributing structures.

The specific anatomical name depends on organism/body part.

AX. FAT CUSHION / FAT PAD

50. **fatty cushion = 脂肪墊**

A layer of fat may:

- * protect;
- * fill space;
- * absorb pressure.

Usually **fat pad** is the more technical common term.

AY. CARTILAGE AS A CUSHION

51. **cushion = metaphor for tissue absorbing pressure**

> “Cartilage cushions the joint.”

「軟骨可**緩衝關節壓力**。」

Here **cushion** is a verb rather than a technical anatomical noun.

AZ. VERB: CUSHION JOINTS

52. **cushion joints = 緩衝關節**

Used for tissue/material that reduces:

- * friction;
- * pressure;
- * impact.

BA. CUE SPORTS: CUSHION

53. **cushion = resilient rubber edge around a billiards/pool/snooker table (桌邊彈性膠邊) **

The World Confederation of Billiards Sports defines the cushion as the cloth-covered rubber bordering the inside of the rails. ([世界撞球聯合會][4])

繁體中文：

* **庫邊**

* **彈性桌邊**

* **橡膠邊**

depending on cue-sport terminology.

BB. HIT THE CUSHION

54. **ball hits/rebounds off the cushion = 球碰庫邊反彈**

> “The cue ball struck the side cushion.”

「母球撞到側面的**庫邊**。」

BC. RAIL VS CUSHION

A useful cue-sport distinction:

rail

structural outer side/frame.

cushion

elastic rubber surface attached to the inner rail.

They are often loosely used interchangeably, but technically they are separate components. ([桌球論壇][5])

BD. CUSHION SHOT

55. **cushion shot = shot involving rebound/contact with the cushion (庫邊球 / 反彈球) **

Terminology varies somewhat by cue sport and coaching context.

BE. CUSHION BILLIARDS / THREE-CUSHION

56. **three-cushion billiards = 三庫開侖**

A carom-billiards discipline in which the cue ball must contact at least three cushions before completing the required scoring contact sequence.

Specialist sports compound.

BF. NATURAL-GAS STORAGE: CUSHION GAS

57. **cushion gas = permanent/base gas kept in underground storage to maintain pressure (墊底氣 / 基礎氣) **

The U.S. Energy Information Administration defines **base gas (or cushion gas)** as gas intended to remain permanently in an underground storage reservoir to maintain adequate pressure and deliverability. ([美國能源資訊管理局][6])

This is a genuine major specialist term.

BG. CUSHION GAS VS WORKING GAS

cushion/base gas

mainly remains in reservoir to maintain operating pressure.

working gas

inventory available for normal withdrawal/use.

EIA explicitly distinguishes them. ([美國能源資訊管理局][7])

BH. MECHANICAL / ENGINEERING CUSHION

58. **cushion = medium/device that absorbs shock at end of movement (機械緩衝) **

Examples can include:

- * air;
- * oil;
- * steam;
- * resilient material.

Older technical dictionaries record, for example, a steam cushion at the end of an engine cylinder to absorb piston impact. ([自由字典][8])

BI. CYLINDER CUSHIONING

59. **cylinder cushioning = 氣缸 / 液壓缸末端緩衝**

In pneumatic/hydraulic systems:

> motion is slowed near the end of stroke to reduce shock.

A common engineering extension of the core impact-absorption meaning.

BJ. PILE-DRIVING / CONSTRUCTION CUSHION

60. **cushion = shock-absorbing element in structural/construction equipment**

Architecture/construction glossaries record several cushion elements used to reduce vibration or receive force, including a **cushion head** protecting a pile during driving. ([İzmir Ekonomi Üniversitesii][9])

Priority: specialist.

BK. CUSHION HEAD

61. **cushion head = protective cap on pile during pile-driving (樁頭緩衝帽) **

Specialist construction term. ([İzmir Ekonomi Üniversitesii][9])

BL. ARCHITECTURE: CUSHION CAPITAL

62. **cushion capital = cushion-shaped column capital (墊形柱頭) **

A Romanesque/medieval architectural capital with:

> a rounded/bulging lower form transitioning to a square upper form.

Architectural glossaries describe it as square at the top and rounded below. ([Impart][10])

BM. BOTANY: CUSHION PLANT

63. **cushion plant = compact low-growing mat-forming plant (墊狀植物) **

Typical especially of:

- * alpine;
- * arctic;
- * subarctic

environments.

The name comes from its dense cushion-like growth form. ([柯林斯詞典][11])

BN. GEMSTONE: CUSHION CUT

64. **cushion cut = gemstone cut with a roughly square/rectangular outline and rounded corners (枕形切割) **

Common especially for:

- * diamonds;
- * coloured gemstones.

Named because its outline resembles a cushion.

繁體中文： ** **枕形切割

BO. PINCUSHION

65. **pincushion = 針插 / 針墊**

A small padded object used to hold:

- * sewing pins;
- * needles.

A lexicalized compound built on the physical cushion sense.

BP. PINCUSHION — FIGURATIVE

66. **feel/look like a pincushion = 被扎滿針似的**

Humorous image, for example after many injections.

This belongs primarily under **pincushion**, not bare **cushion**, but is a useful family extension.

BQ. WHOOPEE CUSHION

67. **whoopee cushion = 放屁聲惡作劇氣墊**

A novelty inflatable cushion that produces a fart-like noise when sat on.

Established compound.

BR. BROADCASTING: CUSHION

68. **cushion = adjustable/removable segment inserted into a broadcast so timing can be corrected (可伸縮 / 刪減的節目時間墊) **

This is a genuine broadcasting term.

Historical radio/TV production terminology uses **cushion** for material whose length can be changed or cut so a program ends on time. ([柯林斯詞典][1])

繁體中文：

* **節目時間緩衝段**

* **可刪減的時間墊內容**

Very specialist/low-priority today.

BS. HAIRDRESSING/FASHION — HISTORICAL

69. **cushion = pad worn under hair to create shape/volume (墊髮) — historical**

Older dictionaries record a pad worn beneath women's hair. ([柯林斯詞典][1])

Priority: historical.

BT. LACEMAKING

70. **cushion = pillow used in making lace (花邊編織枕) — specialist/historical**

Dictionary records preserve this craft sense. ([字典網][12])

More specifically often:

> lace pillow / lace cushion.

BU. GILDING

71. **gilder's cushion = leather pad used when handling/cutting gold leaf (貼金用皮墊) **

Older technical dictionaries record this use. ([自由字典][8])

Priority: specialist craft.

BV. CANADIAN ICE-HOCKEY — RARE/REGIONAL

72. **cushion = ice surface of a hockey rink — Canadian, rare**

Some dictionaries record this regional sense. ([字典網][12])

Very low priority and not recommended for active learner use.

BW. VERB: FURNISH WITH CUSHIONS

73. **cushion = provide/furnish something with cushions (加上軟墊) **

> “The benches were cushioned.”

「長椅加上了**軟墊**。」

BX. CUSHION A CHAIR

74. **cushion a chair = 給椅子加軟墊**

Literal furnishing sense.

BY. BE CUSHIONED BY / WITH

75. **be cushioned by X = be protected/supported by a soft layer or figurative buffer**

> “The package was cushioned by foam.”

「包裹由泡棉**緩衝保護**。」

> “The downturn was cushioned by strong savings.”

「強勁的儲蓄**緩和了經濟下滑的衝擊**。」

BZ. CUSHIONED = PROTECTED FROM SHOCK

76. **cushioned = protected/softened by a buffer (受到緩衝保護的) **

Examples:

* cushioned seat;

* cushioned packaging;

* cushioned landing.

CA. CUSHIONED = FINANCIALLY PROTECTED

77. **financially cushioned = 有財務緩衝保障的**

> “The family was cushioned from the downturn by savings.”

「這家庭因有積蓄而受到一定的**財務保障**。」

CB. CUSHIONY

78. **cushiony = soft and yielding like a cushion (軟綿綿的)**

Informal/low-frequency.

> “The sole feels cushiony.”

「鞋底感覺**柔軟有彈性**。」

For formal writing prefer:

- * cushioned;
- * soft;
- * well-padded.

CC. CUSHION VS PILLOW

cushion

typically used on:

- * chairs;
- * sofas;
- * seats;
- * floors;
- * for support/decoration.

pillow

especially supports the head while sleeping.

Regional overlap exists, but in BrE/Hong Kong English the distinction is generally strong.

CD. CUSHION VS PAD

pad

any relatively flat protective/supporting layer.

cushion

often softer/thicker and emphasizes comfort or shock absorption.

Examples:

- > knee pad
- > sofa cushion.

CE. CUSHION VS PADDING

cushion

individual object or figurative buffer.

padding

soft material/layer used to fill/protect.

- > foam padding inside a helmet
- > seat cushion on a chair.

CF. CUSHION VS BUFFER

Especially important for your passage.

cushion

metaphor emphasizes **absorbing the impact**.

buffer

emphasizes **something kept between you and the disturbance**.

- > financial cushion
- > cash buffer

are very close.

CG. CUSHION VS RESERVE

reserve

resource deliberately held back for future need.

cushion

the protective function that reserve performs.

So:

- > emergency savings = reserve
- > those savings provide a cushion.

CH. CUSHION VS EMERGENCY FUND

emergency fund

specific pool of savings for unexpected events.

financial cushion

broader concept.

A financial cushion could include:

- * emergency fund;
- * other liquid savings;
- * spare income/capacity.

CI. CUSHION VS SAFETY NET

cushion

absorbs/reduces impact.

safety net

catches/protects someone when ordinary support fails.

Examples:

- > cash cushion
- > social safety net.

Very close metaphors, but not identical.

CJ. CUSHION VS INSURANCE

insurance

contractual risk transfer/coverage.

financial cushion

resources retained to absorb losses yourself.

Insurance can form part of overall financial protection but is not itself synonymous with cash cushion.

CK. CUSHION VS CONTINGENCY

contingency reserve

specific amount/resources reserved for uncertainty.

cushion

broader everyday metaphor for additional protection.

CL. CUSHION VS MARGIN

margin

extra amount between actual position and a limit/requirement.

cushion

protective effect of that extra amount.

- > maintain a margin of safety
- > that margin gives you a cushion.

CM. CUSHION VS SLACK

slack

unused capacity/time in a schedule/system.

cushion

extra amount intentionally protecting against disruption.

A project may have schedule slack that serves as a cushion.

CN. CUSHION VS SHOCK ABSORBER

shock absorber

device/component specifically designed to reduce mechanical shocks.

cushion

broader physical and figurative concept.

CO. CUSHION VS PROTECTION

protection

general umbrella.

cushion

specifically reduces severity rather than necessarily preventing the event.

This is important:

> a financial cushion does ****not prevent**** a bad month.

It:

> makes its consequences easier to survive.

CP. CUSHION VS PREVENT

The verb ****cushion**** usually means:

> reduce impact,

not:

> stop the event occurring.

Compare:

> savings ****cushion**** the effect of unemployment

> savings do not ****prevent**** unemployment.

CQ. CUSHION VS OFFSET

****offset****

counterbalance one amount/effect with another.

****cushion****

reduce severity.

> stronger sales offset higher costs

> savings cushion the impact of higher costs.

CR. CUSHION VS ABSORB

****absorb****

take in/bear the force or cost.

cushion

reduce how strongly it is felt.

A reserve may:

> absorb a loss

and thereby:

> cushion the company from the shock.

CS. CUSHION VS SOFTEN

soften

make something less severe generally.

cushion

often implies an intervening buffer/protection.

> soften criticism

> cushion financial impact.

CT. IMPORTANT GRAMMAR

79. **a cushion against + noun**

> a cushion against unemployment

> a cushion against losses.

80. **a cushion for + person/situation**

> "The reserve creates a cushion for difficult months."

Possible, though **against** is often more precise for the threat.

81. **cushion X from + noun**

> cushion households from price rises.

82. **cushion X against + noun**

> cushion the business against shocks.

83. **cushion + direct object**

> cushion the impact

> cushion the fall

> cushion the blow.

84. **be cushioned by + noun**

> cushioned by savings.

85. **cushion of + amount**

For margin/lead:

> “a cushion of ten points”

= 十分領先優勢.

CU. COUNTABILITY

Physical cushion

Countable:

> a cushion

> four cushions.

Figurative financial/protective cushion

Usually countable:

- > a financial cushion
- > an extra cushion.

Cushion as sports margin

Countable:

- > a five-point cushion.

Cushioning

Usually uncountable:

- > extra cushioning
- > good cushioning.

Billiards cushion

Countable:

- > the side cushion
- > three cushions.

CV. FAMILY MAP

Branch	Main meaning	
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cushion — furniture	soft padded support	
cushion — protective pad	layer/object absorbing pressure or impact	
cushion — figurative protection	reserve reducing hardship or loss	
cushion — margin	extra lead/time/money providing safety	
cushion — verb physical	reduce force of collision/fall	

cushion — verb figurative	reduce severity of bad economic/emotional consequences	
cushion — billiards	resilient table edge	
cushion gas	permanent/base gas maintaining underground-storage pressure	
cushion — anatomy	pad-like supporting/protective structure	
cushion plant	compact mat-forming alpine/arctic plant form	
cushion capital	rounded/square transitional architectural column capital	
cushion cut	rounded-corner square/rectangular gemstone cut	
cushion — broadcasting	adjustable/removable timing segment	
cushioning	shock-absorbing material/process	
cushioned	padded or protected from impact	
cushiony	cushion-like and soft; informal	

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
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cushion — furniture	內有柔軟材料、供坐 / 靠 / 支撐身體的軟墊	
seat/back cushion	坐墊 / 靠背墊	
throw/scatter cushion	放在梳化或床上的裝飾靠墊	
cushion cover	套在靠墊外面的布套	
cushion — protective pad	用來吸收撞擊、壓力或震動的緩衝墊	
cushioning	緩衝、緩震效果或相關材料	
cushion an impact/fall	降低撞擊 / 跌落產生的力量	
cushion someone from X	減少 X 對某人的不利影響	
air cushion	用受壓空氣形成支撐 / 緩衝的氣墊	
shoe cushioning	鞋底吸收落地衝擊的緩震性能	
financial cushion	可吸收意外開支 / 收入下降的財務安全墊	
cash cushion	為突發需要額外保留的現金	
liquidity cushion	可快速動用以應付現金需求的流動性緩衝	
capital cushion	可用來吸收損失的額外資本	
budget cushion	預算中預留應付超支 / 不確定性的額外金額	
time/schedule cushion	為延誤等情況預留的額外時間	
a cushion of points/goals	使對手較難追上的額外領先優勢	
give yourself a cushion	主動預留額外時間、金錢或安全餘量	
build in a cushion	在計劃 / 預算中事先加入緩衝餘量	
cushion the blow	減輕壞消息、損失或衝擊造成的打擊	
cushion losses/impact	降低損失 / 不利影響的嚴重程度	
cushion — anatomy	形態或功能像軟墊、能承受壓力的身體組織	
cushion — billiards/snooker	桌邊內側供球反彈的包布橡膠庫邊	
cushion gas	地下天然氣儲存中長期保留以維持壓力的基礎氣體	
cushion plant	在高山 / 寒冷地區形成密集低矮墊狀形態的植物	
cushion capital	中世紀 / 羅曼式建築中上方方形、下方圓鼓的墊形柱頭	
cushion cut	寶石近方形 / 長方形而四角圓潤的枕形切割	
pincushion	插放縫紉針的針墊	
whoopee cushion	坐下時發出放屁聲的惡作劇氣墊	
broadcast cushion	廣播 / 電視製作中可加長、縮短或刪除以調整總時長的片段	

cushioned	有軟墊的；或受到緩衝保護的	
cushiony	非正式：像軟墊一樣柔軟、有彈性的	

For your original passage

> “If you leave now without a financial **cushion**, one bad month may force you to borrow money...”

The metaphor is especially precise.

A real cushion does not stop you from falling.

It:

> **absorbs some of the force when you hit something.**

Likewise, savings do not stop the café from having:

- * weak sales;
- * unexpected repairs;
- * rent increases;
- * supplier problems.

They make those shocks **less damaging**.

So the passage's logic is:

- > no financial cushion
- > → one bad month immediately becomes a crisis.

versus:

- > adequate financial cushion
- > → bad month can be absorbed without desperate borrowing or premature closure.

That is why the next recommendation says Kam Chai should save:

- > twelve months of personal expenses
- >
- > * six months of basic business costs.

Those savings form the proposed **cushion**.

For your core database, I would keep **6 principal semantic branches**:

1. ****soft padded object used for sitting/support****
2. ****protective pad/layer that absorbs physical shock or pressure****
3. ****figurative protection against financial, economic, emotional, or practical hardship — the passage sense****
4. ****extra margin of money, time, points, capacity, etc. providing safety****
5. ****verb: reduce the force or consequences of an impact, fall, loss, or shock****
6. ****specialized cushion-shaped/protective structures — especially billiards, engineering, anatomy, gas storage, botany, architecture****

Then separately index ****financial cushion, cushion the blow, cushioning, billiards cushion, cushion gas, cushion plant, cushion capital, cushion cut****, because these are established enough that the family cannot be safely reduced to simply ****「靠墊」****.

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